July 05, 2025 02:03 PM · Model: auto · 21 messages

USER

give me a detailed summary of each chapter of this book, starting with the introduction. go one chapter per response

TOOL

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Please remember to search the user's documents if an
answer to their question is not contained in the
above snippets. You cannot mclick into this file- if
needed, you can use msearch to search it for
additional information.
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ASSISTANT

Here is a detailed summary of the
of *Pico della Mirandola on Trial: Heresy, Freedom, and Philosophy* by Brian P. Copenhaver:

📘

Brian P. Copenhaver challenges the traditional view of Giovanni Pico della Mirandola as a modern, humanist philosopher. Instead, he argues that Pico's most significant works—including the *Apology* and *900 Conclusions*—are deeply , , and , not progressive or "humanist."

- The *Oration on the Dignity of Man* is often celebrated as a humanist manifesto.
- But Copenhaver asserts that Pico , and its real themes—Christian Kabbalah and mystical annihilation—have been misunderstood.
- The book aims to correct this misconception by focusing instead on Pico's *Apology*, his detailed defense against charges of heresy, which is much more revealing of his intellectual character.

- The book closely analyzes six of the *thirteen "Questions"* from Pico's *Apology*, each responding to a proposition condemned by Pope Innocent VIII.

- These questions are tied to key Christian doctrines: the incarnation, the eucharist, belief and heresy, and the descent of Christ into Hell.

- The *Apology* is presented not as esoteric or poetic (like the *Oration*), but as

.

- Copenhaver applies and to Pico's Latin texts.

- He emphasizes the importance of understanding
  (especially “supposition” and its related vocabulary) which were vital in Pico’s theological reasoning but are opaque to modern readers.

- The book includes of several of Pico’s Questions (Q4, Q8, Q9, Q10) to make his arguments more accessible.

- Pico is placed in the lineage of , not alongside humanists like Valla or Poliziano.

- His Latin style in the *Apology* and *Conclusions* is intentionally scholastic—not the polished, Ciceronian Latin of Renaissance humanism.

- Pico is shown as someone deeply immersed in

  , who viewed himself as a

philosopher in the pre-modern, scholastic sense.

- Copenhaver critiques the as a visionary of Enlightenment.

- Instead, he offers a picture of a young aristocrat with a , , and to reconcile religious traditions, but within the terms of a medieval framework.

- This book is addressed to scholars across multiple disciplines: history, theology, literature, philosophy, law, and Renaissance studies.

- It also seeks to engage , encouraging them to take historical metaphysical and semantic debates seriously.

- Copenhaver's ultimate goal is to : the scholastic, late-medieval tradition, rather than the proto-modern humanist myth.

Would you like the summary of Chapter 1 ("Humanism Goes to Hell") next?

USER

continue

ASSISTANT

Here is a detailed summary of from *Pico della Mirandola on Trial: Heresy, Freedom, and Philosophy* by Brian P. Copenhaver:

📘

🔧

- , especially the *900 Conclusions* (1486), *Apology* (1487), and *Heptaplus* (1489).

- These texts , not humanist eloquence. Pico explicitly said he was writing in the style of philosophers in Paris, not in “splendid Roman” Latin.

- The set up by Pope Innocent VIII to investigate the *900 Conclusions* was populated by clerics steeped in scholasticism—Dominicans, Augustinians, Franciscans, and others.

🔍 *Key detail:* Pope Innocent condemned 13 of Pico's theses within weeks and ordered an inquisition, showing how seriously theological disputes were taken.

- Copenhaver retells , including a in the *Apology* where Pico ridicules one commissioner's reliance on the *Fasciculus Temporum* (a popular chronicle) rather than Greek sources. Another commissioner is mocked with a pun on "testes" (witnesses/testicles).

- This personal and rhetorical aggression shows Pico's arrogance, but also his commitment to using scholastic methods.

📙

- The Pope condemned —a central doctrine of the

Church. These are addressed in Q6, Q9, and Q10.

- Pico proposes that Christ's body can be present on the altar *without* the bread being annihilated or changed—this challenges conventional views on transubstantiation.

- He uses terminology like *substantia*, *paneitas* (breadness), *suppositum*, and *veritas sacramenti*, drawn from , not from humanist sources.

- Pico's metaphysical innovation: a theory of "sustaining breadness" (*substentatio paneitatis*) that allows the real presence of Christ's body without the annihilation of bread.

🧠 *Important point:* These are not idiosyncratic ideas but grounded in a

, especially via Jean Cabrol and Pierre de la Palud.

⚖️

- Copenhaver places Pico's *Apology* in a wider , referencing Berengar of Tours (11th century), John Wyclif (14th century), Jan Hus (burned at the stake in 1415), and the Hussite Utraquists.

- By proposing alternative theories of the Eucharist, . Heresy on this issue had previously led to excommunication, exile, or execution.

📜

- The concerns Christ's descent into Hell—a doctrine included in the Apostles' Creed.

- The issue: how could Christ, a bodiless soul after crucifixion, be *in* Hell if

? The metaphysical problem of *bodiless spatiality* is central.

- Pico explores this through analogies with , citing questions about Jacob's Ladder.

- Again, Copenhaver shows how Pico employs , rather than rhetorical or poetic modes, to resolve deep theological puzzles.

🔒

- This section leads toward , concerning belief, will, and heresy.

- A central issue in the *Apology*: whether incorrect belief is heretical *only* when held willfully.

- Pico argues that beliefs are not entirely voluntary: to be a heretic, someone must

choose to believe wrongly. This question of "doxastic voluntarism" places Pico in dialogue with thinkers like William of Ockham and Adam Wodeham.

- Pico does not just defend his theses; he

.

- He accuses the papal commissioners of ignorance, cowardice, and corruption—again undermining his chances of acquittal.

- —

an attitude that further distances him from the ethos of humanism as conciliatory civic rhetoric.

- Copenhaver documents of medieval scholasticism: raise a question, present objections, give a resolution.

- The Apology is structured as 13 “Questions,” not as a continuous argument or narrative, and uses with citations to Thomas Aquinas, Scotus, Ockham, Henry of Ghent, and others.

- Pico draws heavily on logic—especially —to analyze theological statements.

- He is not arguing by faith alone but by between how words refer, what kinds of things they refer to, and how meaning is constructed.

- The stakes are high:
  if they lead to theological heresy.

☠️

- Copenhaver concludes the chapter by summarizing the 13 condemned theses and their grouping:

- Incarnation, Hell, and Worship
- Kabbalah
- Eucharist
- Miracle, God's Unity, and the Soul

🧷 Key insight: The core theme is

—how God can be body, how bodies can be in Hell or on altars, and what it means to believe these things.

✅

—a brilliant but arrogant young man deeply immersed in complex theological debates that cost others their lives. His *Apology* is not a humanist gesture but a scholastic disputation in the face of inquisitorial prosecution.

Would you like a summary of next?

USER

give me an overview of the apology as discussed in the text

ASSISTANT

Here's an overview of ***Apology*** as it is discussed throughout Brian P. Copenhaver's *Pico della Mirandola on Trial: Heresy, Freedom, and Philosophy*:

📘

🏛️ ***Apology***

Pico della Mirandola's *Apology* (1487) is a large and technical defense of his earlier work, the *900 Conclusions*, which had drawn accusations of heresy from Pope Innocent VIII. The *Apology* is structured as a of the Pope's condemnation of selected from the *Conclusions*. These rebuttals are organized into in scholastic format.

> 📌 The *Apology* is Pico's most revealing philosophical work— , which he never gave and which was deliberately esoteric.

🧠

Apology :

- It uses technical Latin drawn from scholastic theology, not Ciceronian elegance.

- Pico's argumentative method is modeled on the : raising objections,

citing authorities, analyzing logical terms.

- It is [redacted] —especially the medieval theory of [redacted] (how words refer to things in logical propositions).

📚 [redacted] : Thomas Aquinas, Duns Scotus, William of Ockham, Henry of Ghent, Jean Cabrol, Pierre de la Palud, and others.

🚫 [redacted]

⚖️

- The *Apology* is Pico's [redacted] after the papal commission condemned 13 of his *Conclusions*.

- The inquisitors were not neutral judges but [redacted], selected from various religious orders and predisposed to condemn him.

- Pico uses the *Apology* both to argue and to of his judges, even mocking them—hardly a conciliatory gesture.

📖

Each section of the *Apology* responds to a condemned thesis. While all 13 Questions are covered, , namely:

Q1	Christ's Descent into Hell	How a bodiless Christ can be "in" Hell
Q4	Incarnation	Divine embodiment and metaphysics
Q6, Q9, Q10	Eucharist	Real presence, transubstantiation, semantics of liturgical words
Q8	Belief and Heresy	Is heresy willful? Can belief be coerced?

The rest of the *Apology* touches on:

- Kabbalah (almost incomprehensible to Pico's judges)

- Defense of Origen (more philological than theological)

- Miracles, divine unity, and the soul

Copenhaver shows that the *Apology* is

:

- Pico's defense hinges on of terms like *substantia*, *accidens*, *suppositum*, *materialiter*, and *veritas sacramenti*.

- Much of the *Apology* is an attempt to , using .

- Words like "this" in the Eucharistic formula ("This is my body") are analyzed using —e.g. , , and .

⚔️

While highly technical, the *Apology* is also:

- : Pico insults and mocks the judges; he defends his orthodoxy not meekly, but aggressively.

- : He perceives the trial as unjust and uses philosophical argument to fight back.

- : Far from advancing modern or progressive ideas, Pico's ambition is to show his , albeit through a complex metaphysical lens.

🕊️

Copenhaver's core argument is that the *Apology* dismantles the image of Pico as a

humanist hero of modernity or Enlightenment.

Instead, he is:

- A .
- A , not challenging it.
- A defending his honor through aggressive reasoning.

🧪

- to a Renaissance Latin text.
- Provides of key Questions.
- Reconstructs the of Pico's arguments through medieval sources.

- Revives the *Apology* as a [illegible] work in understanding both Pico and late medieval philosophy.

✅

Pico's *Apology*, as analyzed by Copenhaver, is:

- A [illegible], not a manifesto.
- A [illegible], text.
- A [illegible] written under threat of excommunication.
- A [illegible], not the Renaissance vision of autonomous human dignity.

Would you like a breakdown of a specific Question (like Q4 or Q6)? Or shall I continue with

Chapter 2 next?

USER

continue with chapter 2

ASSISTANT

Here is a detailed summary of from *Pico della Mirandola on Trial: Heresy, Freedom, and Philosophy* by Brian P. Copenhaver:

📘

This chapter delves into the Pico uses to defend himself in the *Apology*. Copenhaver argues that without understanding the medieval Pico draws on—especially the theory of —modern readers will completely misread the text. This is the chapter that opens up Pico's and is crucial for understanding the rest of the book.

🎭

- Copenhaver begins with a paradox: Pico has been taken seriously as a , but his actual style in the *Apology* is riddled with .
- To many humanists (and moderns), these arguments are "gigantic jokes"—not in the sense of being funny, but of being .
- Yet these jokes had : semantic distinctions about

how words function were central to heresy trials.

- Medieval scholastics developed centered on how words “stand for” things. This became especially important in theology.

- Copenhaver explains that Pico , especially via thinkers like Ockham, Buridan, and Peter of Spain.

- Pico’s vocabulary is drawn from this tradition: terms like *suppositum*, *suppositio*, *significatio*, *appellatio*, *ampliatio*, and *restricto* appear again and again in the *Apology*.

⚖️

- —sometimes misunderstanding technical terms as heretical ideas.

- For instance, the word *suppositare*—an unusual, invented verb used by Pico—was attacked for sounding suspicious or impious, even though it was rooted in a well-established technical tradition.

- —but the judges didn't necessarily understand those meanings as Pico did.

- Words like "angel," "body," and "substance" are grammatically singular, but may stand for .

- Scholastics had to distinguish , especially in

theological contexts (e.g., “God,” “the Church,” “man”).

- Pico exploits these distinctions in *Apology* Q1 and Q4 to address issues like how Christ or angels could occupy space or time *without* bodies.

📎

- Medieval logic recognized as distinct metaphysical entities (e.g., paternity, equality).

- Copenhaver shows how (e.g., *relativum*, *aliquid ad aliquid*) to explain paradoxes such as how the divine can be *in relation* to material things without being changed.

- This is crucial in discussing the Eucharist (Q6, Q9, Q10), where Christ’s body must be present but not changed in nature.

- This section focuses on *suppositio*, the most important technical term in the chapter—and one that appears in Pico's *Apology*.

- *Suppositio* deals with in a given proposition: for example, does "Christ's body" refer to the divine person, the human nature, the bread, or something else?

- Pico insists that

  , and many of his arguments depend entirely on these subtle distinctions.

Supposition is not grammar—it's a logical system for how words relate to reality in propositions.

- Pico criticizes humanist grammar (e.g., Lorenzo Valla) as for theology.

- Instead, he relies on (like those of Priscian and the Modistae), which tried to align .

- For Pico, , not stylistic ornament.

- Copenhaver emphasizes that , but deeply .

- For example, the phrase “This is my body” in the Eucharist has to be analyzed semantically—what does “this” refer to?—not symbolically.

- Theological doctrines such as the Trinity and Incarnation depend, in Pico’s eyes, on .

- Pico often uses technical terms *without defining them*, assuming that his readers (or judges) would understand.

- Copenhaver explains that this has contributed to centuries of misreading Pico.

- *suppositio materialis*, *praesuppositio*, *subiectio*, *praedicatio*, *esse in re*, etc.

- The chapter ends by contrasting Pico's semantic logic with humanist ideals of clarity, elegance, and eloquence.

- While humanists like Valla, Poliziano, and Erasmus valued linguistic *purity*, Pico valued

.

- Copenhaver argues that when arguing about the Eucharist or the Incarnation—, even if it meant sounding barbarous.

✅

>

For Pico, , and so he built his defense with meticulous attention to how language works in logic, philosophy, and theology. Copenhaver's chapter unlocks this , revealing Pico not as a prophet of modernity, but as a .

Would you like to continue with next?

USER

give me a deep dive on Pico's treatment of angels and its scholastic contexts

ASSISTANT

Pico della Mirandola's treatment of is one of the most philosophically sophisticated and theologically loaded components of his thought, woven through his *900 Conclusions*, the *Apology*, and his broader metaphysical and cosmological vision. Brian P. Copenhaver, in *Pico della Mirandola on Trial*, touches on this primarily in of the *Apology*, where the issue of angels intersects with debates about the , , and .

What follows is a into Pico's angelology in its , synthesizing Copenhaver's treatment with some necessary background:

In of the *Apology*, Pico confronts a metaphysical problem:

> How can a descend into a like Hell after the crucifixion but before the resurrection?

This leads to an analogous question:

> How do , also , move through space or appear in space?

Because angels, like the soul of Christ between death and resurrection, are:

- Immaterial
- Intellective substances
- Not bound by space in a bodily way

- Yet frequently described in and as acting and

Pico uses the example of (Genesis 28:12), where angels a ladder, to raise the broader issue of for immaterial beings.

🧰

The problem of was a , dealt with by:

- *Summa Theologiae*, I, q. 52–53

- Argued that angels are (like bodies), but : they are present *by acting on a body* in a specific location.

- Angels do not occupy space, but are .

- Accepted Aquinas's model but introduced refinements on the , sometimes leaning toward or .

- Critiqued some of Aquinas's distinctions.

- Emphasized that angels could be and "move" by , without any *local motion* in the bodily sense.

- Influential for on the Incarnation, and by extension, Q1 on the descent into Hell.

- Proposed more of divine and angelic presence—helpful to Pico's emphasis on of how beings can be "in" space.

🧬

🚶

How can an angel "move" from one place to another without undergoing (change in position)?

- Answer: Not motion in the Aristotelian sense, but a change in .

- This analogy supports Pico's : the soul descends *not by movement*, but by .

📍

How can an immaterial thing be *in* a place?

- Pico, following scholastics, uses : an angel is present .
- In *Apology* Q1, this provides a model for saying that , though not located in the way a body is.

🗣️

Because “being in a place” can mean —circumscriptively, definitively, or presentially—Pico leans on to clarify what kind of reference each term carries in theological propositions.

💡

Pico links the to the :

- Christ, in his , descends into Hell.
- This descent is but real.
- Since angels are commonly accepted to be in a place without bodies, this gives for asserting the same of Christ's soul.

"The angelic example serves as a for how Christ can be said to be *in* Hell without a body" (Copenhaver, Ch. 1.4).

🚫

The papal commission was :

- They judged Pico's use of this metaphysical subtlety as , , or .
- They emphasized of creedal statements, e.g. "He descended into Hell" meant , not metaphor or analogy.

Pico counters:

- The statement can be , given a proper theory of presence.

- Misunderstanding comes from , not doctrinal error.

✨

Outside the *Apology*, especially in the *Oration* and *900 Conclusions*, Pico famously:

- Engages deeply with the of Pseudo-Dionysius.

- Uses angels as , which humans can ascend through .

- Embraces the as intellective forms that human souls can imitate and surpass.

In that more mystical register:

- Angels become not just metaphysical examples, but to the human condition.

- The human capacity to becomes a central claim in his vision of .

✅

Angels provide a model for how
—used to justify
Christ's descent into Hell

Follows Aquinas, Ockham, and Henry of Ghent in analyzing
of spirits

Helps resolve logical contradictions in key
using

Pico's defense rests on *understanding angels correctly*—his accusers' failure to do so reflects theological incompetence

In *Oration* and *900 Conclusions*, angels represent stages of —humans can rise above them through divine knowledge

---

Would you like a companion summary of how angels function in the *900 Conclusions* or *Oration*, or a closer look at Pico's engagement with Pseudo-Dionysius?

USER

continue with the next chapter

ASSISTANT

Here is a detailed summary of

from *Pico della Mirandola on Trial: Heresy, Freedom, and Philosophy* by Brian P. Copenhaver:

📘

This chapter examines of Pico's *Apology*, which addresses the : specifically, . The central issue is the metaphysics of divine embodiment— without change, error, or heresy.

Copenhaver uses this chapter to show Pico's dependence on — especially —and how he uses to defend orthodoxy in the face of accusations of heresy.

🔍

Pico's original thesis that prompted papal condemnation (from *900 Conclusions*) stated:

> "Christ did not take on human nature, but rather assumed a man."

This wording triggered alarm because it

—a classic Nestorian heresy.

But Pico argues in *Apology* Q4 that this is a , and that his

phrasing is orthodox .

A central scholastic distinction is at stake here:

- refers to *what* something is (e.g., humanity, divinity).

- refers to *who* someone is (a concrete individual).

Pico's argument:

- If Christ assumed only *human nature*, that implies he took on a , not a .

- Therefore, to say that Christ assumed —an individual person—is not Nestorian if one understands that the assumed human "person" was not , but .

🧩 This is extremely subtle: Pico is not denying the unity of Christ's person, but in how we describe that unity.

📚

Pico draws directly from , a scholastic theologian who developed a rich vocabulary for analyzing personhood and nature.

Copenhaver identifies Henry's influence in:

- The concept of *suppositum*: the concrete subject of attributes (person, in effect).
- The problem of in the incarnation: is Christ one suppositum or two?
- The need to distinguish between (human nature) and (in an individual).

Henry had tried to argue that Christ assumed who , but became individualized in union with the Word.

This is Pico's line, too.

Pico's defense is technical:

- He argues that the proposition "Christ assumed a man" is ; it depends on how the terms and are used.

- He distinguishes between and :

- *"Man"* materially supposes (refers to) the word or concept
- *"Man"* formally supposes (refers to) the actual human individual

Using this machinery, Pico tries to show that:

- His statement does not entail Nestorianism

- It is
  under scholastic interpretation

Copenhaver emphasizes that

—he is being a

, defending

himself with the tools of .

⚔️

The papal commission read Pico's conclusion

, and saw Nestorian heresy:

- If Christ assumed "a man," then there must be

in Christ (divine and human)

- This is , contrary to the Chalcedonian Creed

But Pico contends that their reading

and :

- There is no second hypostasis or suppositum

- "A man" refers not to a separate person, but to a complete human nature individuated in Christ

---

📖

Pico uses to support his claims:

- Creed: “He was incarnate by the Holy Spirit of the Virgin Mary and became man”
- He argues that “became man” can be semantically equivalent to “assumed a man,”

This appeals to the , not against it.

🧠

Copenhaver highlights that Pico’s defense is:

- Deeply rooted in
- Not an attack on Christian doctrine, but a

- An attempt to , not undermine them

In this sense, Pico models a working in the mode of Thomas, Henry, or Scotus—not a modern critic or reformer.

✅ ***Apology*** . He enters the thorniest debates of Christology—how divine and human natures are united—and defends himself using:

-
-
- A commitment to

Far from undermining the faith, Pico tries to protect it with the tools of philosophy. The real problem, Copenhaver suggests, is that his judges

lacked the conceptual training to understand his defense—and thus, misunderstood orthodoxy itself.

Would you like to continue with next?

USER

tell me more about Pico's engagement with Dionysius

ASSISTANT

Pico della Mirandola's engagement with —or simply Dionysius—is both and , spanning his mystical theology, angelology, metaphysics, and even aspects of his rhetoric and cosmology. Though Copenhaver's *Pico della Mirandola on Trial* focuses primarily on Pico's *Apology* and its scholastic logic, Dionysius is a , especially for understanding Pico's intellectual formation and the mystical hierarchy that underlies even his more scholastic arguments.

Here is a detailed account of Pico's Dionysian engagement—both , based on Copenhaver's framework and extended by Pico's other writings (like the *Oration*, *Heptaplus*, and *900 Conclusions*).

📘

🕊️

, a Christian Neoplatonist writing under the pseudonym of the Athenian convert of Paul (Acts 17:34), was considered

,

especially for:

- The
- The doctrine of
- The metaphysics of and (exitus-reditus)
- The of the cosmos

📌 Dionysius stood at the intersection of

, a space Pico loved to explore.

Copenhaver notes (especially in Ch. 1 and in footnotes across the book) that:

- Pico read , often and him in his *900 Conclusions*, *Oration*, and *Heptaplus*.
- He accessed Dionysius likely through the , which had been widely used in the Middle Ages.
- Dionysian concepts appear , especially in the , and implicitly undergird his ideas of mystical ascent.

In *900 Conclusions*, several theses (especially in the theological and mystical sections) refer to the and , core Dionysian themes.

👼

Pico's angelology, which plays an important role in both the *Apology* and *900 Conclusions*, is

Celestial Hierarchy.

- The cosmos is organized into (Seraphim, Cherubim, Thrones, etc.), each mediating light and divine knowledge.
- Angels reflect God's presence , and act as .
- The angelic ladder becomes a , which can be through philosophy, magic, and mystical experience.

- He controversially claims that , which but doesn't contradict him—it fulfills the Dionysian structure through (theosis).

⚠️ Though Pico celebrates angelic order, he also proposes that —a tension with Dionysius's more conservative ordering.

🌀

Dionysius is famous for advocating :

- God is beyond being, beyond knowing, and beyond naming.

- The , but through , silence, and negation.

Pico incorporates this in:

- His , which culminates in the idea that the soul, after ascending through various orders of knowledge, must pass into .
- His , where the soul ascends through sephirotic levels into , a notion resonant with Dionysian negation.

🔍 In this light, Pico sees , where the true names of God dissolve into silence and unity.

Dionysius sees all knowledge of God as , symbols, and sacramental realities.

Pico takes this seriously:

- In his *Heptaplus*, he treats the as a , where

, a technique drawn from Dionysius's symbolic theology.

- He insists that and can operate as —ways to intuit divine truths embedded in nature.

This is also present in the *900 Conclusions*, where are defended , if properly understood.

Dionysius inherits from Plotinus and Proclus the idea that:

- All things (exitus)
- And strive to (reditus)

Pico structures much of his metaphysical and mystical thinking around this:

- The soul is to ascend or descend.

- Through , it can and return upward toward unity.

This undergirds the of human dignity: that man is placed at the center of the cosmos with the freedom to ascend to angelic heights or descend to brute materiality.

💡 by emphasizing human freedom and self-fashioning, but the metaphysical architecture is .

✅

Triadic celestial orders mediate divine light	Embraced and integrated into mystical anthropology (esp. in *Conclusions*)
God beyond being and knowledge; mystical union in darkness	Deeply influential in *Oration* and Kabbalistic synthesis
Reality reveals divine truth through signs and sacraments	Seen in Pico's allegorical readings (e.g., *Heptaplus*) and in magic
Exit from and return to the One through hierarchical ascent	Foundational to Pico's model of human perfectibility and philosophical striving
The final goal is a union with God that transcends knowledge	Echoed in Pico's blending of Platonic eros, Kabbalah, and Dionysian mysticism

---

- *Celestial Hierarchy* and *Mystical Theology* by Pseudo-Dionysius (Latin via Eriugena for Pico)
- Pico's *Oration on the Dignity of Man*, especially the ladder of ascent
- *900 Conclusions*, theological and magical sections (especially where he integrates Dionysius with Kabbalah)
- Copenhaver's introduction and Ch. 1–2 of *Pico on Trial* for positioning Pico between scholastic and mystical traditions

---

Would you like a comparison between in Pico's synthesis, or a close reading of Dionysian themes in the *900 Conclusions* or *Oration*?

USER

give me a reading of Pico's treatment of Dionysius in De Ente et Uno Chapter III. From the testimony of Parmenides, of Dionysius, and of Simplicius, we conclude the convertibility of unity and being.

This word being, concerning which there is doubt whether it is equal to the concept unity, can be taken in two senses. The first is this: When we say 'being' we may mean anything that is outside of nothing. This is the sense of the word with Aristotle, wherever he makes being equivalent to unity. And this meaning is not unreasonable, for, as it is truly said, we ought to think with the few, but talk like the many. We think and judge for ourselves; we speak for the multitude, and we speak so that we may be understood. The vulgar, then, the unsophisticated, so understand being that they call anything 'being' (ens) which does not lack existence (esse), and which cannot properly be called nothing. But do we not find that those who are considered the wisest among the opposition22 have not understood being in any other way? 22. I.e. the Neo-Platonists who make unity superior to being.

When Parmenides the Pythagorean said that the one is that which is, he meant God, if we credit Simplicius23 and all the many others who want to

defend Parmenides against those who falsely accuse him of saying that all things are one.24 For they all agree in answering that, in employing the word 'one', Parmenides never believed that division, multiplicity, and plurality do not attach to things, since in other passages of his poems he himself openly affirms the contrary. But, they say, when he said 'one' what he meant is that to which the name of being truly applies, and which is truly the one being (esse), which one is God. Thus, for Parmenides and his defenders, even the 'Platonists,' the one cannot be above being unless it be above God. However, far from denying that God is being, it is to God alone that Parmenides accords, as is in truth fitting, the name of being. And so we solve the first difficulty of the 'Platonists.' 23. Simplicius, In Phys., (ed. H. Diels, Berlin, 1882) t. I, p.147, 12.

24. The universe -- a pantheistic interpretation, the only legitimate one, Cf. Cornford, op. cit., 29: "This One Being is not a mere abstraction; it proves to be a single continuous and homogeneous substance filling the whole of space."

As regards Dionysius the Areopagite,25 whom our opponents invoke in favor of their opinion,

he will not deny that God verily said to Moses: 'I am who am,' which reads in Greek: egw eimi o wn, that is, 'I am being' (ens). Of a truth, they themselves, when they say that nothing, or non-being is opposed to being as the many to the one, concede that of necessity that which is not being is nothing or non-being, in just the same way that what is not one is multiple or plurality. However, if they observe the same manner of speaking, they must say either that God is nothing, which appalls the ears, or that He is being. But to understand being in this fashion is to return to that which we have established as the first axiom and universal proposition, namely, that concerning anything it is necessary to say that it is or is not, and that concerning anything it is impossible to say or think both together at the same time. Since, therefore, outside of everything there is nothing but nothingness itself, if being understood in this sense excludes nothing but only nothingess, it is evidently necessary that being encompass all that is. Therefore the extension of unity cannot be greater unless it included nothingness itself, a possibility which Plato denies in the Sophist when he says that non-being or nothing cannot be called one. Besides, if unity cannot have less extension than

being, it follows that being and unity must be convertible concepts. 25. Cf. The Divine Names, I, paragraph 6 (Patrologia Graeca, vol. III, 596 A-B). A convenient English translation of this work as well as of the Mystical Theology may be found in C. E. Rolt, Dionysius the Areopagite, (Macmillan, 1920).

Chapter IV. In what sense one can say that something is superior to being.

We have explained one of the senses which we said could be given to being. Understanding it so, -- a perfectly legitimate usage of the word -- one affirms most truly that there is nothing more common than being. It remains to explain the second sense, according to which it will be manifest that one can no less justly say that there is something that surpasses in eminence being itself.

Words are either concrete or abstract. Concrete are, for example, hot, bright, white, man; abstract: heat, light, whiteness, humanity. This is their power and diversity: that what is called abstract connotes that which is such by itself (a se), not by another (ab alio), while concrete signifies that

which is what it is not by itself, but by virtue of another. Thus the luminous is such in virtue of light, the white is such through whiteness, and man is man by virtue of his humanity. Moreover, since there is nothing which participates in itself, and since the same thing cannot possess the same quality at the same time by itself (a se) and by participation in another thing, it follows that the abstract cannot take its denomination from the concrete. Wherefore it is incongruous to say that whiteness is white, blackness black. Indeed, it is ridiculous to speak thus, not because whiteness is black or heat cold, but because such is the distance of the one from blackness and of the other from coldness, that all that is white is so by participation in the first, and all that is hot is so by participation in the second. When, then, we refuse to attribute such or such qualities to such or such an object, it is either because that object does not possess them, for example in the expression "black is not white," or because we want to signify that it possesses them in a more excellent and more perfect way than we do: as when we deny that whiteness is white, not because it is black, but because it is whiteness itself.

But let us return to the subject. The word 'being' (ens) has the aspect of a concrete word. For to say 'being' (ens) and to say 'that which is' (id quod est) is to say the same thing. The abstract of this would seem to be the word esse, in that one calls ens that which participates in esse, in the same way that one calls luminous that which participates in light.26 If we look at this meaning of being which we have thus defined, we shall have to deny being not only to that which is not, and to that which is nothing, but also to that which is so that it is that being (esse) itself which is of itself (ex se) and by itself (a se), and by participation in which all things are: just as we not only deny that that is hot which lacks heat, but also that which is heat itself. Now, such is God, the plenitude of all being, the sole being a se, and from Whom alone, without the intervention of any intermediary, all things have come to be.

26. The language here is Platonic.

We have, therefore, the right to say that God is not being but is above being, and that there is something to being, namely God Himself. If we give to God the name of the One, it follows that we avow the one to be above being.

However, in calling God the One, we do so less to indicate what He is than to show in what manner

He is all that is, and how other beings are through Him, 'God is called the One,' says Denys, 'because He is in a unique way all things,'27 and again: 'God is called the one because He is the principle of all things, just as unity is the principle of all numbers.28 Wherefore if (as the Academy pretends) Plato, in the first hypothesis of the Parmenides, affirms that the one is superior to being, that one will be nothing else than God. They (the Academy), indeed, themselves recognize this, since they admit by universal consensus that Plato here treats of the first principle of all things.29 27. The Divine Names, I, paragraph 7. (P. G., III, 596 D).

28. Ibid., II, paragraphs 4 and 11; V, paragraph 6.

29. Plotinus, Ennead V, I, 8. The Parmenides of Plato distinguishes the First One, or the one in the proper sense of the word; the second, which he calls the One-Many; and the third, or 'One-and-Many.' The First One is for the Neo-Platonists God Himself.
But, some will say, on this point at least Aristotle differs from Plato, for Aristotle never understands being as subordinate to the one and as not including God in its extension. Those who speak

in this way have not read Aristotle, for he does this very thing, and much more plainly than Plato. In the sixth book of his Metaphysics30 he divides being into being-by-itself (per se) and being-by-accident (per accidens). When being-by-itself (per se) is divided into ten categories, there is no doubt on the part of good interpreters of the philosopher that God is not included under this being, since He is neither being-by-accident nor is He contained under any one of the ten classes into which being per se is divided. Nothing is more of a commonplace among the Peripatetics than that division of being into substance and accident. Since this is so, we understand being so that God is above being and not below it, as St. Thomas himself teaches in the first book of his Commentaries on the Theological Sentences.31 I shall add that certain Platonists do wrong in vaunting themselves as if they possessed a secret unknown to Aristotle, when they say that God has two proper appellations, namely, the One and the Good, as if the good and the one were superior to being. Just as we have demonstrated that it did not escape the Peripatetics in what sense God can be understood as superior to being, so we are able to show that it was particularly these two names, the Good and the One, that Aristotle gave

to God. 30. Metaphysics, E, 2, 1026 ff.

31. Commentum in libros IV. Sententiarum Magistri Petri Lombardi I, dist. xix, q. 4, ad 2 and esp. dist. xxiv, q. I, a. 1.

In the second book of the Metaphysics,32 after having treated of being in its totality and of separate minds,33 he asks finally (as if, after all the rest, he wanted to turn to the investigation of the attributes of God alone), if, besides the good which is in the universality of things as in an army, there were some separate good like the person of the chief of this army, and he answers that this good exists, and that it is God. Of this God, in the same chapter, he demonstrates the unity, citing in testimony of this, after strong arguments, the phrase of Homer; eiz koiranoV estw, eiV basileuV.34 Where then is his error? Where is Aristotle at odds with Plato? Wherein is he profane? Wherein does he fail to give God the honors which are due to Him? 32. Metaphysics, A.

33. This book of the Metaphysics first studies sensible substance in its elements and its structure (ch. 1 to 5), then incorporeal immobile substance (ch. 6 to 10). The complex problem of the different first movers is touched on in ch. 8.

The comparison with the army occurs in ch. 10, 1075 a 11 ff.

34. 10, 1076 a 4. Cf. Iliad II, 204. Pico misquotes Aristotle, who quotes Homer correctly: ouk agaqon polukoiranih: eiV koiranoV estw.

Chapter V. In which is shown why the Peripatetics attribute to God many qualities which the Platonists deny Him, and how one may ascend through four degrees even to the cloud which God inhabits.35

35. This entire chapter is inspired by the Mystical Theology of the Pseudo-Denys.

Let us respond now to the arguments which the Platonists invoke to sustain against Aristotle -- not in the sense with which we agree, but absolutely speaking -- the superiority of the one over being. We have, I think, already answered adequately the first of these arguments by which God is considered one and nevertheless is not being, but it is worth the labor to pursue the discussion in order to show that not only with the Platonists and Peripatetics, who disagree with one another, but often in the same single writer, there can be, with respect to the divine attributes,

many affirmations and many negations equally just.

God is everything, and he is everything in the most eminent and perfect way. Now, He would not be this unless He included in Himself all perfections in such a manner that He rejected all that has to do with imperfection in things. However, one must distinguish two kinds of imperfection. On the one hand, that is imperfect which in its class does not attain the perfection of that class or type. On the other, that is imperfect which, although perfect of its kind, is not absolutely perfect, because it has only the perfections of its kind, and there exist outside of it a number of kinds of things enriched with perfections that are proper to them and which, on its part, it does not include. As an example of the first case consider sense-knowledge, the imperfection of which comes not only from the fact that it is merely knowledge, and not appetition, but also from the fact that it is an imperfect kind of knowledge, both because of the organs which it must use, and which are brute and corporeal, and because it attains only to the superficial aspects of things and does not penetrate to the innermost reality, namely, the substance. So likewise is that human knowledge

which one calls rational an imperfect knowledge, being vague, uncertain, mobile, and laborious. Even the intellectual knowledge36 of those divine intelligences called angels by the theologians, is nothing but an imperfect knowledge, if only because of the obligation it is under to seek without that which it does not possess within, at least in plenitude, namely, the light of truth which it needs for its actuation. 36. 'Intellectualem cognitionem,' (Mirandola) This is the classical distinction between discursive thought, logoV dianoia, and intuitive thought, nomsiV According to the Mystical Theology, ch. 3, It is necessary to pass beyond both before attaining God.

Take another example: life. The life which resides in plants, indeed that which moves every body, is imperfect not only because it is life and not appetition, but because it is not pure life, but rather an influx of life derived from the soul in the body, constantly flowing, constantly mixed with death, fitter indeed to be called death than life. Are you unaware of it? We begin to die as soon as we begin to live, and death extends along with life, so that we stop dying only at that instant when corporeal death delivers us from the body of this death.37 But even the life of the angels is not perfect: unless the unifying ray of the Divine

light incessantly vitalized it, it would slip completely into nothingness. So for all the rest. When therefore you make God knowing and living, attend first to this, that the life and knowledge which you ascribe to Him be understood as free from all these detriments. 37. Cf. I Corinthians XV, 31; Romans VII, 24.

But this is not enough. There remains the second kind of imperfection, of which the following is an example.38 Imagine the most perfect kind of life possible, a life completely or perfectly alive, having in it nothing mortal, nothing mixed with death, a life which needs nothing outside or itself by means of which to remain stable and permanent. Imagine likewise a kind of knowledge which perceives everything at once and perfectly. Add this: that he who thus knows all things, knows them in himself and need not search outside himself the truth to be known, but be himself the very truth. Nay, to whatever high degree of perfection this life and this knowledge have attained in their proper natures, and though one could find them nowhere except in God, if, even in this degree of perfection one divides the one from the other, they are unworthy of God.

38. On this point cf. the Mystical Theology, chapters 4 and 5.

For God, in short, is perfection in all its modes and in an infinite manner, but He is not such perfection merely because He comprehends in Himself all particular perfections and those in infinite number. For in that case, neither would He Himself be perfectly simple, nor would the perfections which are in Him be infinite; but He would be nothing more than a unique infinite, composed of many things infinite in number but finite in perfection.39 Now, to think or speak so of God is blasphemous. However, if the most perfect life possible is nonetheless only life, and not knowledge, and the same for all other similar perfections which are assembled in God, there will manifestly ensue a divine life of finite perfection, since it will have the perfection which pertains to life and not that which pertains to knowledge or to appetition. Let us then take from life not only that which makes life imperfect, but also that which makes it life merely, and do the same as regards knowledge and the other qualities which we have ascribed to God. Then what remains of all this will necessarily correspond to the idea which we want to have of God, namely, a Being one, absolutely perfect, infinite, altogether simple. And since life is a certain particular being, and wisdom likewise, and

justice, if we remove from them this condition of particularity and limitation, that which remains will not be this or that being, but being itself, simple being, being universal, not with the universality of attribution but with the universality of perfection.40 Similarly wisdom is a particular good, because it is that good which is wisdom, and not that other which is justice. Take away, says St. Augustine,41 this, and take away that, that is to say, this limitation of particularity by which wisdom is that good called wisdom, and not that good called justice, and by which, similarly, justice has the particular goodness of justice and not that of wisdom; then only will you see in an obscure way42 the face of God, i.e. all good in itself, simple good, the good of all good. So also as life is a particular thing, it is one particular thing. For it is a certain perfection; and similarly wisdom is a certain perfection. Cast off the particularity, and there remains, not this or that unity, but the one itself, the absolute One. Since therefore God is that being which, as we said in the beginning, when the imperfections of all things are removed, is all things, certainly that which remains when you have rejected from all things both that imperfection which each one possesses in its kind, and that particularity which

reduces each to one kind, will assuredly be God. God is, then, Being itself, the one Himself, the Good, and the True. 39. On this distinction between the quantitative infinite and the infinite of perfection, cf. St. Thomas, Summa Theologica, I, q. 7, a. 1 to 4.

40. That is to say, not abstract analogous being, but this concrete infinite being which is God.

41. Cf. Enarrationes in Psalmos, (Migue Patrologia Latina vols. XXXVI-XXXVII, 1490, 1741) in Ps. cxxxiv: "Dixit (Deus) Ego sum qui sum . . . non dixit Dominus Deus ille omnipotens, misericors, justus . . . Sublatis de medio omnibus quibus appellari posset et dici Deus, ipsum esse se vocari respondit et tamquam non esset ei nomen, hoc dices eis, inquit, qui est misit me."

42. 'In enigmate' (Mirandola). Cf. the Mystical Theology on this matter of the Divine darkness. In thus purifying the Divine names of all the stains that come from the imperfection of the things signified by them, we have already moved two steps in the ascent to the cloud which God inhabits. There remain two more, one of which indicates the deficiency of language, the other

the weakness of our intelligence.
These terms: being (ens), true, one, good, signify something concrete and as it were participated; wherefore we say again of God that He is being (esse) itself, truth itself, goodness itself, unity itself. Thus far indeed we are in the light, but God has placed His dwelling in the shadows.43 We have then not yet come to God himself. So long, in short, as that which we say of God is fully understood and entirely comprehended, we are in the light. But all that we say and perceive thus is a mere trifle, considering the infinite distance which separates Divinity from the capacity of our minds. In climbing to the fourth step we enter into the light of ignorance,44 and, blinded by the cloud of the Divine splendor, we cry out with the Prophet: 'I have fainted in Thy halls, O Lord,'45 finally declaring this one thing about God, that He is incomprehensibly and ineffably above all that we can speak or think of most perfect, placing Him pre-eminently above that unity and that goodness and that truth which we had conceived, and above being (esse) itself. Thus Denys the Areopagite, when he had written his Symbolic Theology, his Theological Institutes,46 the treatise on the Divine Names, and the Mystical Theology, and come to the end of the

last-mentioned work, like a man already, so to speak, standing in the darkness and trying to find words most adequate to God, after some essays exclaimed: 'He is neither truth nor kingdom, nor unity, nor divinity,47 nor goodness, nor spirit, as we know it; one cannot apply to Him the names of son or of father or of any other things in the world known to us or to any other being. He is nothing of that which is not, nothing of that which is. Things which are do not know Him as He is, nor does He know things as they are.48 of Him there is no definition, neither is there a name nor a science of Him. He is neither darkness nor light, neither error nor truth,49 in short, every affirmation and every negation in regard to Him is equally impossible.' This is how that divine man expresses it. 43. Psal. XVII, 12: 'Et posuit tenebras latibulum suum, in circuitu ejus tabernaculum; tenebrosa aqua nubibus aeris.'

44. Cf. the 'superessential light of the Divine darkness' in the Mystical Theology, ch. I, paragraph 1, and the De Docta Ignorantia of Nicholas Cusanus. The latter work is available in a new critical edition by E. Hoffmann and R. Klibansky (Leipzig, 1932).

45. Psal. LXXXIII. 3: 'Deficit anima mea in atria Domini.'

46. I.e. the Hypotyposes theologicae. Cf. the Mystical Theology, ch. 3, where all these works are named.

47. Cf. C. E. Rolt's note (Dionysius the Areopagite, N.Y., 1920, p. 200, No. 2): "Godhead (divinity) is regarded as the property of deified men, and so belongs to relativity."

48. Cf. Rolt (ibid., 200, No. 3): "It (God) knows only Itself, and there knows all things in their Super-Essence-sub specie aeternitatis."

49. Rolt (200, No. 4): "Truth is an object of thought. Therefore, being beyond objectivity, the ultimate Reality is not Truth. But still less is it Error." I should rather say that truth is a relation or quality, and that since God transcends all relationship and all quality, He is not truth but THE TRUE.

Let us gather up our conclusions. We learn, then, in the first degree, that God is not body, as the Epicureans say, nor the form of a body, as those say who affirm that God is the soul of the sky and

of the universe -- the opinion of the Egyptians, according to the testimony of Plutarch50 and Varro the Roman theologian,51 whence they draw great nourishment for idolatry. Yet there are some even among the Peripatetics52 so stupid as to hold this the true doctrine and moreover as the teaching of Aristotle. How far they are from knowing God truly! They rest in the starting-place as if they had already reached the goal, and believe themselves already come to the heights of the Divinity while in fact they are lying on the ground and have not even begun to move a foot towards Him. For from this point of view God could be neither perfect life nor perfect being nor even perfect intelligence. But we have elaborately confuted these profane opinions in the fifth section of our Concordia.53 50. De Iside et Osiride, 49. Osiris is the nouV of the world-soul, Typhon its paqhtikon, seat of the passions.

51. De lingua latina, V, 10.

52. Allusion to the Averroist school at Padua.

53. I.e. the Symphonia Platonis et Aristotelis described in my Introduction, p. 4, above.
We learn, in the second degree, a truth which few

men understand correctly, and in regard to which we risk deceiving ourselves the more however little we deviate from true intelligence, namely, that God is neither life nor intelligence nor intelligible, but something better and more excellent than all these. For all these names state one particular perfection, and there is nothing of the sort in God. Mindful of this, Denys54 and the Platonists have denied God life, intellect, wisdom, and the like. But since God unites and gathers up in Himself by His unique perfection which is His infinitude, in short, Himself, the totality of perfection which is found is these divided and multiplied, and because He does this not as a unity composed of these multiple perfections, but as a unity anterior to them, certain philosophers, especially the Peripatetics,54a imitated insofar as is permissible on almost all these points by the theologians of Paris,54b concede that all these perfections are in God. We agree with them, and we believe that in so doing we are not only thinking justly but that we are at the same time in agreement with those who deny these same perfections, on condition that we never lose sight of what St. Augustine says,55 namely, that God's wisdom is not more wisdom than justice, His justice not more justice than

wisdom, nor His knowledge more knowledge than life. For all these things are in God one, not by confusion of mixture, or mutual penetration of distinct entities, but by a simple, sovereign, ineffable, and fundamental unity in which actuality, all form, all perfection, hidden as if in the supreme and pre-eminent jewel in the treasury of the Divine Infinity, are enclosed so excellently above and beyond all things that it is not only intimate to all things, but rather united with all things more closely than they are with themselves. Assuredly words fail us, altogether unable to express this concept. 54. Mystical Theology, chapter 5.

54a. Pico is no doubt referring here to the authentic Aristotelian tradition of Alexander and Thimistitis (the latter lately edited by Ermolao Barbaro) which found itself opposed, in the 15th century, to the Arabianizing tradition and to the Averroism of Padua.

54b. Especially St. Albert and St. Thomas.

55. Cf. Sermo CCCXL, I, ch. 5 (P. L. 38, 1482); ch. 7 (ibid., 39, 1498).
But see, my dear Angelo, what folly possesses us!

While we are in the body we are able to love God better than we can know or describe Him. In loving there is for us more profit, and less labor , the more we obey this tendency. Nevertheless, we prefer constantly to seek through knowledge, never finding what we seek, rather than to possess through love that which without love would be found in vain. But let us return to our subject. You already see plainly by what convention one can call God spirit, intelligence, life, wisdom, and on the other hand place Him above all these determinations, both having good proofs to witness to their truth and their accord. Nor does Plato dissent from Aristotle, because when, in the sixth book of the Republic,56 he calls God "the idea of the Good" which surpasses intelligibles, he shows Him giving to Intelligence the power of intellection, and to intelligibles their intelligibility,57 while the latter of them (Aristotle) defines God as the being who is at once intelligence, intellect, and intelligible.58 Denys the Areopagite, also, though he talks like Plato, is nevertheless obliged to affirm with Aristotle that God is ignorant neither of Himself nor of other beings; wherefore, if He knows Himself, it is because He is both intelligence and intelligible; for he who knows himself is necessarily both

knower and known. And yet, if we consider these perfections as particular perfections, as I have said, or if, when we say intelligence, we mean to signify that nature which tends to the intelligible as to something exterior to itself, there is no doubt that Aristotle, like the Platonists, would firmly deny that God is intelligence or intelligible.
56. Republic VI, 509 b, where God is called, not an essence, but something far above essence in dignity and in power.

57. "Et intelligibilia statuat dantem illis quidem ut intelligant, his autem ut intelligantur."
(Mirandola.)

58. Cf. Meta., A, 7, 1072 b 20.
In the third degree, the more we approach the darkness, the more light we have to see that not only is God not (impious to say!) something imperfect or a mutilated being, as He would be if we called Him a body, or the soul of a body, or an animated being composed of soul and body, nor some particular genus however perfect, which human wisdom can fashion,59 like life, or spirit, or reason, but that we ought to conceive of Him as superior to all that these universal terms which include in their extension all things, i.e., the one,

the true, the good, and being, signify. 59. Cf. I Corinthians II, 13: "Quae et loquimur non in doctis humanae sapientiae verbis sed in doctrina Spiritus, spiritualibus spiritualia comparatites."

In the fourth degree, finally, we know Him as superior not only to these four transcendentals, but also to every idea which we could form, to every essence which we could conceive Him to be. Then only, with this total ignorance, does true knowledge commence.

From all this we conclude that God is not only the being than which, according to St. Anselm,60 nothing higher can be conceived, but the being who infinitely transcends all that can be imagined, as David the prophet put it in the Hebrew: "Silence alone is Thy, praise."61 60. Proslogion, ch. xv (P. L., 158, 235): "Domine, non solum es quo majus cogitari nequit; sed es quiddam majus quam cogitari possit."

61. Psal. LXIV, 2: "Tibi silentium laus" (St. Jerome's translation).

So much for the solution of the first difficulty. The window is now wide open for a true understanding of the books composed by Denys the Areopagite on Mystical Theology and The Divine Names. Here we must avoid two mistakes:

either to make too little of works whose value is great, or, seeing that we understand them so ill, to fashion for ourselves idle fancies and inextricable commentaries.

ASSISTANT

Pico della Mirandola’s treatment of in *De Ente et Uno*—especially in and culminating in —reveals a of with , , and a nuanced grasp of scholastic theological method. This engagement is not merely rhetorical: it demonstrates Pico's attempt to and integrate into a comprehensive metaphysical system.

Below is a deep reading and interpretation of Pico’s use of Dionysius:

🧷

Pico opens Chapter III with a [illegible]:

> Are *unity* (unum) and *being* (ens) convertible—that is, do they apply equally to all that exists?

This question is ancient, central to both [illegible] and [illegible] traditions, and foundational in scholastic ontology. To answer it, Pico invokes [illegible], [illegible], and [illegible] as authorities for a traditional metaphysical intuition: [illegible]—and that [illegible] is to participate in unity.

He is writing against unnamed opponents (likely Platonizing theologians) who hold that [illegible]—a common reading of [illegible], and one that appears in the [illegible] of Plato's *Parmenides*. But Pico carefully distinguishes [illegible] to resolve the issue.

🧠

1. (Aristotelian/common usage):
- This is the inclusive, “vulgar” sense—*ens* is anything that is not *non-being*.
- Dionysius himself accepts this when citing the (“I am that I am” / *Ego sum qui sum* / *ἐγώ εἰμι ὁ ὤν*).

2. :
- This is a sense: *ens* is that which .
- Just as a luminous thing receives light, a “being” participates in esse.
- By this model, God in being— (*ipsum esse per se subsistens*), and therefore, in the participial sense.

—his language is accommodated to a scholastic and Thomistic metaphysics of participation.

In , Pico makes the :

"God is not being, but above being."

This apophatic turn is directly inspired by ***Mystical Theology***. Pico explains it with :

- like “hot” or “luminous” imply participation.
- like “heat” or “light” imply essence or source.
- So too, “being” (*ens*) implies participation in *esse*, but God esse.

Thus, just as whiteness is not white,

.

📖 Dionysius’s formula, cited by Pico:

“God is called the One because He is in a unique way all things” (Divine Names I.7).

This enables Pico to explain how:

- God (life, wisdom, justice) in a way that transcends .
- God is not *this* or *that* perfection but .
- Thus, God is not just *perfect life* or *perfect wisdom*, but —a central Dionysian idea.

In , Pico formalizes the Dionysian mysticism as a toward the divine cloud:

1	God is not body or soul, not the world-soul.	Anti-Epicurean, anti-Stoic, anti-Averroist
2	God is not even life, intellect, or being.	Dionysius, Augustine
3	God is above unity, truth, goodness, being.	*Mystical Theology* I–III

4	God is beyond any concept or name; is fitting.	Dionysius, Psalm 64:2: *"Tibi silentium laus."*

Pico quotes Dionysius directly on the

of God:

> "He is neither truth nor unity nor being… not father or son or spirit… neither darkness nor light… every affirmation and every negation is equally impossible."

This mirrors the conclusion of *Mystical Theology*, where Dionysius through a final negation.

Pico with :

- Like Aquinas, he affirms that —but we must implied in each term.

- Unlike some Platonists, he does not reject divine attributes entirely; instead, he insists

they are

.

- Augustine is invoked to support this unity: God’s wisdom is not more wisdom than it is justice— .

At the end of Chapter V, Pico turns personal and spiritual:

> "We are able to love God better than we can know or describe Him."

This final insight is thoroughly Dionysian and

:

- at the summit; .
- The intellect seeks endlessly;

.

This resonates with Dionysius's idea that

—and even with later thinkers like , whose *Docta Ignorantia* Pico would have known.

✅ *De Ente et Uno*

Unity is above being; God is beyond being	Pico accepts this , but insists that in , being and unity are convertible
God is beyond affirmation and negation	Pico elaborates this into a , ending in silence and ineffability
God is all things in a unique way	Pico aligns this with scholastic simplicity:
True knowledge is darkness, not light	Pico quotes Dionysius and Augustine to affirm that transcends all our concepts, even the transcendentals

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Would you like a similar analysis of how Pico incorporates Dionysius in his *Oration on the Dignity of Man* or the *900 Conclusions*? Or perhaps a comparison between Dionysius, Cusanus, and Kabbalistic sources in Pico's mystical epistemology?

USER

tell me more about how Pico brings in Thomistic realism

ASSISTANT

Pico della Mirandola's synthesis of —particularly the metaphysical and theological framework of —is one of the most subtle and distinctive features of his intellectual project. In *De Ente et Uno*, as well as in the *Apology*, *900 Conclusions*, and the *Concordia*, Pico neither blindly follows Aquinas nor breaks with him in a polemical spirit. Rather, he draws deeply on , especially his , while filtering these through a .

Below is a close reading of how , especially in *De Ente et Uno*, but also across his corpus.

📘

📐

A key feature of is the :

- Creatures being; they are composed of and .
- God being itself—*ipsum esse subsistens*—with no distinction between essence and existence.

📍 ***De Ente et Uno***

> *"Ens is that which participates in esse, just as the luminous participates in light."*

This is a —found also in *Summa Theologiae*, I, q. 3, a. 4:

> *"In God, essence and existence are the same, whereas in creatures they differ."*

: all beings are beings by participation in God's act of being. This view grounds his affirmation that:

- God is *above being* only in the sense that He , but rather the .

- *Ens commune* (common being) includes all things that exist *except* God, who is *beyond genus*.

🧠 : Being is real, objective, and structured; creatures truly participate in esse, and this participation grounds the *hierarchy of reality*.

⚖️

Aquinas insists that:

- God's attributes (wisdom, justice, power, etc.) are not in Him.

- Each attribute is , and they are only in our minds.

📍 ***De Ente et Uno***

> *"God's wisdom is not more wisdom than justice… all these things are in God one… by a simple, sovereign, ineffable unity."*

He echoes in God:

- If God had multiple, distinct perfections, He would be composed and therefore .
- Instead, God is in an —not a sum of parts.

This is central to Thomistic realism: , yet allows a realist account of divine attributes as truly meaningful.

🧠

Aquinas defines (being, one, true, good) as properties that are —they apply to all things that are.

📌 ***De Ente et Uno***

> *"Being and unity must be convertible concepts."*

Pico's affirmation of is pure . His difference lies in how he that God is "above being":

- For , "above being" must be understood carefully, because God is not but —*not ens commune*, but *esse ipsum*.

- Pico agrees: God is "above" being not as to it, but as its .

In this way, . He accepts that:

- The transcendentals can be insofar as they imply .
- Yet they are also insofar as they point analogically to the .

📌 This is Aquinas's , though Pico doesn't name it directly: names of God are not univocal (same meaning), nor equivocal (totally different), but .

🧩

Pico draws heavily on :

- *Suppositum, essentia, esse, actus, potentia*—all are deployed in his *Apology* and *De Ente et Uno*.
- These terms carry a —they refer to , not merely mental constructs.

Thomistic realism is not merely linguistic—it is

:

- Universals are grounded in

.

- Meaning is not only in language but in

.

Pico accepts this basic ontology:

- The mind knows real things through their

.

- Truth is the

(*adaequatio intellectus et rei*—another Thomistic formula).

Modifies ***Extends***

While Pico draws on Aquinas, he does not remain within the strict bounds of Thomism. He innovates or *inflects* it in several ways:

Apophatic, but less central	He amplifies Dionysius, making
God is Being Itself	God is being when being is participial;
	allows him to affirm both
Analogical predication	Pico moves more easily between , often affirming and denying simultaneously
Knowledge is exalted, but love is not excluded	Pico puts in mystical ascent—closer to Dionysius and Augustine

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✅

ST I, q. 3, De Ente et Essentia	Essential to his account of participation
ST I, q. 3, q. 13	Affirms unity of all perfections in God
ST I, q. 5, *De Veritate*	Uses them as a ladder to God, then negates them
ST I, q. 13	Implied in his treatment of divine names
Aristotelian/Thomistic via Avicenna	Accepted, though enriched by Platonic participation
Secondary in Aquinas	Central in Pico—especially via Dionysius and Cusanus

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Would you like a summary of Pico's *Concordia* and how he tries to reconcile , including Thomism and Platonism? Or a breakdown of how Pico's use of

plays out in his *900 Conclusions* or Kabbalistic writings?

USER

let's move on to the next chapter of Copenhaver

ASSISTANT

Here is a detailed summary of from *Pico della Mirandola on Trial: Heresy, Freedom, and Philosophy* by Brian P. Copenhaver:

📘

This chapter is devoted to Pico's treatment of in his *Apology*, which addresses one of the most theologically delicate and metaphysically complex topics in Christianity: the . Specifically, it focuses on the of Christ's body in the consecrated bread and wine of the Mass, a doctrine that had long been a site of controversy, precision, and peril.

Copenhaver shows that : a dense, exacting argument that draws on theories of , , and , particularly concerning the words of consecration—"This is my body."

🍞

The key dogma in question is :

- Defined at the and reaffirmed at , it holds that the of the bread becomes the substance of Christ's body, while the (taste, smell, appearance) remain.

- This doctrine relies heavily on , particularly as interpreted by Aquinas.

The challenge Pico faces:

> How can the words “This is my body” be true if the bread remains in any form?

One of Pico’s *900 Conclusions* stated:

> *“The body of Christ is not really and truly in the sacrament.”*

This is —a direct challenge to the Church’s teaching. But Pico insists in Q6 of the *Apology* that:

- His thesis was .

- What he meant is not that Christ is absent from the sacrament, but that the in the sentence *“This is my body”* —

that is, it does not refer to a physically present body in the way ordinary speech would imply.

🧠

Copenhaver shows that Pico's defense turns on the :

- *Suppositio materialis*: when a word refers to itself as a word.
- *Suppositio formalis*: when a word stands for a concept.
- *Suppositio personalis*: when a word stands for the actual thing it signifies.

In "This is my body," Pico argues that the term "body" —it

—because:

- The physical body of Christ is on the altar.

- Rather, it is present , by , not by ordinary reference.

🧵 The sentence “This is my body” is true, but . It is , not semantically.

📚

Copenhaver traces Pico’s logic to and , both of whom had proposed subtle alternatives to the standard interpretation of transubstantiation.

- These thinkers tried to explain the in ways that preserved orthodoxy while , such as the annihilation of the bread's substance.

- Pico draws on their ideas to introduce the concept of (*substentatio paneitatis*), where

, not as a deception, but as .

This leads Pico to propose:

- The of the sacramental statement lies not in of the sentence, but in — what it brings about.

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†

Copenhaver clarifies Pico's strategy:

- He is not denying the .
- He is denying that the functions like an ordinary descriptive sentence.
- It is more like a —a statement that , not merely describes it.

Pico, then, anticipates a of sacramental language: the , not in conventional semantics.

> 💡 This makes the sacrament in the structure of language: it is a rather than a normal linguistic proposition.

🧱

Copenhaver emphasizes that Pico's argument has deep :

- It challenges the naive realism of .
- It insists that , especially when the .
- It preserves orthodoxy while rejecting of consecration.

Pico also warns against [illegible] — treating sacred language as though its [illegible] exhausts its [illegible].

📖

Despite his careful distinctions, Pico's position was [illegible]:

- The papal commission condemned his thesis.
- His explanation required [illegible], which his judges lacked.
- His [illegible] in the *Apology*—mocking and adversarial—did not help his cause.

Still, Copenhaver argues, Pico was not attempting to undermine the Eucharist but to [illegible].

✅

In Q6, Pico confronts the doctrine of [illegible] not with denial but with

:

- He affirms the of Christ in the sacrament.
- He denies that the has in the ordinary sense.
- He appeals to a to argue that is not reducible to .
- He insists that —their power is , not grammatical.

Copenhaver reads Pico here as a , not a modern critic. His theology is not progressive, but , and his danger lies in .

Would you like to continue with next?